

23
BATTING INDIA IS BATTLING INDIA

MOHALI. 30 March 2011.

The sun is down. The Indians have just won their fifth World Cup match against us. This one was a semi-final and has only added more sheen to their already-perfect record.

This match stands out. I'm captain of the Pakistan side. The X-Man celebration stance – some call it the Star Man – is now a standard on T-shirts across Pakistan. There's even a music video somebody's made for the World Cup, remixing it as 'Shahid Afridi'. That is about as good as it gets for me, though. I can see my career fading towards its sunset. And my dream – to win the World Cup in India – is already over.

Back to the field. Match over. The presenter at the awards ceremony asks me a question. I'm trying to smile.

'First of all, I'd like to congratulate the Indian cricket team and the Indian nation for this great victory, and wish them all the best for the final,' I manage to say. The crowd roars. 'Wahab really bowled well today but we missed some opportunities. They played better than us. We didn't make partnerships, we played some irresponsible shots and a partnership was crucial. I want to say sorry to my nation. We tried our level best and we enjoyed ourselves at this tournament.'

The crowd roars again. I walk off. And with me, our longest run for the World Cup trophy since 1999 comes to a sudden end.

That day, in Mohali, our nerves got the better of us. Sure, we were missing Asif and Amir – new-ball spearheads any team would be helpless without – due to the spot-fixing scandal, but we bounced back with a hell of an attack. Wahab Riaz, the left-arm swing specialist; Umar Gul, right-arm fast-medium; Saeed Ajmal, the *doosra* master; Abdul Razzaq, right-arm medium and as accurate as a military sniper; me … We were all firing, even that day.

Let's be honest. We lost that game more than India won it. India's cricket god, Sachin Tendulkar, was the luckiest man in the world that day. We dropped him on 27, 45, 70 and 81. He would finally be dismissed on 85.